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TRANSLATING SIKH SCRIPTURE INTO ENGLISH

bed puran simrit sadhu jan

eh bani rasna bhakhi

Vedas, Puranas, Simritis, and saintly people

utter this language in their tongue

(Guru Arjan, GG, 1227)

As for the posited central kinship of languages, it is marked by a distinctive convergence. Languages are not strangers to one another, but are, a priori and apart from all historical relationships, interrelated in what they want to express.

(Walter Benjamin, 'The Task of the Translator', in Benjamin 1969)¹

Sikh scripture, the Guru Granth, was compiled by Guru Arjan (Nanak V) in 1604. Although the historical relationships amongst different communities in his milieu were acrimonious, the Sikh Guru did not get stuck on external differences of accents, intonations, grammar, structure or vocabulary. Through his profoundly personal sensibility, he heard the 'distinctive convergence' of languages expressed by Hindus and Muslims alike: 'koi bolai ram ram koi khudai – some utter Ram; some Khuda' (GG, 885). Whatever resonated with the voice of the founder Guru Nanak – 'bhakhia bhau apar (language of infinite love)' – Guru Arjan included it in the sacred volume for his community. Written out in the Gurmukhi script, the Granth contains the poetic verses of the Sikh Gurus along with those of Hindu Bhaktas and Muslim Sufis. Clearly Guru Arjan heard their language emerge from a singular matrix that transcended discords of Sanskrit and Arabic, polytheistic and monotheistic, eastern and western, ancient and modern, classical and vernacular. The Guru Granth repeat-edly affirms the genuine affinity of species and languages, for after all, they have a common source. Says Nanak I: 'khani bani teria – species and languages are yours' (GG, 580); the third: 'ape khani ape bani ape khand varbhand kare – you yourself are the species, you yourself are the languages, you yourself create the continents and constellations' (GG, 552); and the fifth: 'teria khani teria bani – yours are the species, yours are the languages' (GG, 116). The kinship of language is intensely felt and loudly expressed throughout Sikh scripture.

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Unfortunately, its English translations wreak alienation. They impose all sorts of dualisms and divisions, and reduce and distort the original as though it were in an entirely alien tongue. In the case of these translations, languages do become ‘strangers to one another’, and we do not get the genuine taste of the Guru’s words. The first English translation of Sikh scripture was made by the German missionary linguist Ernest Trumpp in 1877, but because of its blatant orientalism, it had an extremely negative reception. Since then, there have been several popular versions, including that of Max Arthur Macauliffe (1909), Gopal Singh (1960),² Manmohan Singh (1962), Gurbachan Singh Talib (1977), and the electronic version available at srigranth.org. However, as a Sikh feminist scholar, who grew up on the poetry of the Guru Granth, I am left disappointed. These English translations seem to me to be products of andro-centric hermeneutics. My dissatisfaction actually goes way back to my undergraduate years at Wellesley College. I remember coming across Rabindranath Tagore’s translation of ‘Arati’. Since I greatly admired Tagore (and still do!) I was disappointed that even the great poet’s translation did not bring out the full beauty of Nanak’s evening hymn that I had heard daily at home. The deep relationship among languages at the heart of Sikh scripture has not been carried (latus) across (trans) by either Sikh or non-Sikh translators.

In recent years, I have ventured to translate some of the scriptural verses and found that Punjabi actually lends itself quite well to the English language. So I wholeheartedly adopt Benjamin’s popular perspective that ‘Languages are not strangers to one another, but are, a priori and apart from all historical relationships, interrelated in what they want to express.’ As we look at our global reality with its religious rips and gashes, and all its economic, political, military and cultural hegemonies, it becomes vital that we recover our intrinsic kinship. Benjamin’s classic essay on the task of the translator takes on a new urgency in our rapidly shifting world with vast diasporas, and fast financial and information networks.³ We must think of new ways of translating Sikh scripture so that we recover the true relationship between Punjabi and English – and our common humanity.

Intimacy of the reader

Any genuine relationship requires intimacy, so translators must first become intimate readers of the original text. In her invigorating manner, Gayatri Spivak articulates this basic requisite:

But no amount of tough talk can get around the fact that translation is the most intimate act of reading. Unless the translator has earned the right to become the intimate reader, she cannot surrender to the text, cannot respond to the special call of the text.⁴

Like the good old German word ‘*Unterstand*’, a reader must literally stand closely under the text – surrendering utterly to the original. But this simple task can be most difficult. ‘[E]ntering the protocols of a text – not the general laws of the language, but the laws specific to this text’⁵ – can be daunting, especially, for readers as they try to enter the sacred text of another’s religion. Grounded in

one's own faith and ideology makes it difficult to surrender to the faith and ideals of others. Moreover, the academy posits virtues of objectivity and scholarly distance that brace readers to approach texts with considerable detachment. For whatever reasons then, be it their personal proclivities, religious ideologies, or academic methods, non - Sikh scholars have been unable to surrender themselves completely to 'the special call' of the Sikh text.

For those within the tradition, translation of their scripture poses another set of problems. This is no book; this is their Guru eternal. A day before Guru Gobind Singh passed away, he made the Granth, the guru for perpetuity. In their daily liturgical prayers Sikhs recite 'guru granth ji manio pargat guran ki deh – know Guru Granthji as the manifest body of the Gurus'. That a scripture is the living body of their Ten Gurus is indeed a very unique and innovative phenomenon in the history of religions. The Hebrew Bible, the Vedas, the New Testament, the Quran are absolutely significant in their respective traditions. But in no case do they embody the Jewish Prophets, or the Rishis, or the Evangelists or the Prophet Muhammad. In the Sikh instance the Granth is literally the Guru. Intersecting both space and time, it is the very body of the Gurus. The scriptural body palpates with the inhaling and exhaling of the Gurus, it palpates with their diastolic and systolic movements, it flows with the flow of the Gurus' blood. In public worship and privately at home, Sikhs revere their Guru ardently: they perform prakash (opening the Guru Granth in the morning) and sukhasan (putting it in bed at night), and verbally communicate with the Ultimate through vak (reading of the passage on the top left page as the Granth is opened at random). The holy text is carried on the head, it is fanned with a whisk, and men and women with their heads covered and barefooted bow in front of it. Daily the Book is dressed in beautiful brocades and silks. Sikhs seek its presence for all their rites and ceremonies.

Ironically, however, Sikhs regard the Guru Granth as the soul of the Gurus and construct unnecessary chasms rather than relate to this vibrant body with intimacy. In my experience, whenever I happen to mention the corporeal aspect of the sacred text, I meet with a lot of hostility from male Sikhs. I am told loudly and clearly that the Guru Granth is the 'soul' of the Gurus, which must not be confused with their 'body'. At some ineffable level, Sikhs deny the physicality of the Guru Granth. They view the 'body' pejoratively, and refuse to see the Granth as the body of their Gurus. There is thus a terrible incongruity between what we hear Sikhs recite and how they actually understand those words. The centuries-old taboos against the body in their patri-archal milieu happen to be reinforced through the English dichotomy of body – soul by their colonial experience. These doubly thick patriarchal lenses inhibit them from recognizing the new and liberating vision of their Gurus, with the result that the body – spirit dualism and its drastic corollaries enters into their translation of their scripture.

In fact intimacy is at the heart of Sikh sacred text, and for me a verse from the first Guru illustrates it perfectly:

ghan saci sanguti

hari sang suti

(GG, 843)

The woman abides in truth,
intimately locked in the divine embrace.

Here we encounter a woman whose sexuality is healthy and wholesome. She is the scriptural model who incarnates physical beauty and spiritual awakening and she can rapturously make love with her divine lover. She is important for the translation process too. For as she graphically expresses the intimacy of the human – divine relationship, she urges us to read the sacred text intimately – with our bodies, senses, mind, intellect and spirituality. With her we learn to enter the protocols of the sacred text and experience the infinite melody of love. Sikh scripture provides many such powerful images that overturn fears of intimacy prevalent in our culture, and inspire us to enter exciting new horizons with all of our human faculties. ‘To surrender in translation is more erotic than ethical’ says Spivak,⁶ and here interest-ingly we have in the original a woman who, morally refined, is erotically locked in the arms of her Lover, her surrender at once erotic and ethical.

In the absence of intimacy between the text and the reader, there cannot be genuine translations. Consequently, adaptations in English are marred by aberrations and distortions. Stuck in their habits and cramped by their inhibitions, readers are unable to open themselves to the freedom and spontaneity of the original. A simple scriptural verse like ‘tohi mohi mohi tohi antar kaisa – between you and me and me and you what difference can there be’ is misunderstood as submission to an omnipotent lordly ‘God’ out there who can only be related through supreme ‘thous’ and ‘thees’. Such archaic terms amply imported into English translations destroy the immediacy and inclusivity of the Sikh verses. This has been a problem with translations from India for a long time. Yeats correctly identified it when he commented that the works of eminent scholars are strewn with latinized and hyphe-nated words, ‘polygot phrases sedentary distortions of unnatural English . . .

muddles, muddled by “Lo! Verily”, and “Forsooth” . . .’⁷ Yeats was talking about the Upanishads when he made this remark. Things may have improved in major Hindu texts, but unfortunately there still hasn’t been much change in trans-lations of Sikh literature. Whether within or outside of the Sikh faith, readers seem to surrender themselves not to the original text but to their visceral notions of an omnipotent God out there. This idea of the holy far, far away, does not allow them to have intimacy with ‘his’ literary context – perhaps that would even be threatening for them. Whereas the original celebrates the divine as inti-mately present in and with everybody, we find translators over and over inserting archaic phrases that exalt and extol and lend mystique and authority to That One, making ‘him’ wholly distant and other. ‘Hallowed be thy name’ that is still used in English is adapted in Sikh scriptural translations. This weird archaic Jacobean phrase is completely incomprehensible to modern speakers. Perhaps ‘God’ is won-dering why people are talking to him in this funny language that he has not heard for five hundred years! Religious Jacobean English is distanced from everyday English, and when it is used in the Sikh context, it becomes doubly foreign, alienating and misleading.

Parity of languages

And this brings me to my second point: there ought to be parity between languages.

How can we have any meaningful relationship between two unequal entities? In all

translations of scripture, Punjabi has been totally subservient to English. The imperial language with its own set of meanings, connotations and structures has dominated the source language, and a one-sided 'globalization', which is merely westernization, has monopolized Sikh scriptural translations. Contemporary scholars warn us about the manipulative activity underlying such a one-sided translation process: 'Translation is not an innocent, transparent activity but is highly charged with significance at every stage; it rarely, if ever, involves a relationship of equality between texts, authors or systems.'⁸ English words imbued with Jewish and Christian meaning have come to dictate Sikh ideals. Key theological concepts from western philosophical tradition – alien to Sikh worldview – bury scriptural translations and obstruct any real affinity between Punjabi and English.

Even in post-colonial India the master – subject relationship of the British Empire continues to operate, and the vitality of the scriptural language and the refreshing new vision of the Gurus is suppressed by the master's words. During the colonial process when many young Sikh lads wore British uniforms and heroically fought for the empire in distant parts, many influential Sikh theologians and exegetes studied western texts and imbibed western religious-philosophical ideas. This multifaceted British legacy continues to spur Punjabi Sikhs to study English and western philosophies and literatures, drawing them away from their mother-tongue and their literary heritage. Indoctrinated in English-speaking schools, which were founded by Victorian colonialists, many Sikhs do not even possess the basic linguistic tools to understand their sacred text. Jewish and Christian vocabulary and worldview are internalized and continue to be reproduced in modern translations. Younger generations of Sikhs in Canada, England and America are not familiar with the original verse. Sadly, it is in his master's voice that many Sikhs relate with their sacred book.

I feel it is absolutely essential that Sikh translations be freed from all oppressive veils and weights. As Walter Benjamin has said,

A real translation is transparent; it does not cover the original, does not block its light, but allows the pure language, as though reinforced by its own medium, to shine upon the original all the more fully.⁹

There are three words in the English medium that I consider particularly detrimental to Sikh scriptural translations. They are God, Lord and Soul. Each of them is a tiny short little word, but thick and heavy with implications that cover up the original, obscure its light, and prevent it from reaching out to us. To make matters worse, they are patriarchal gender paradigms, and they buttress male dominance and superiority. They espouse sexist language, which discriminates against women – utterly disregarding their role and presence. Not only do they harm one half of Sikh society, these three misogynistic tools have a terrible effect on Sikh thought and behavior overall. Our translators of course are obsessed with them. The website srigranth.org uses the terms 'God' 5,195 times, 'Lord' 7,500 times, and 'Soul' 1,315 times! And so very often there is literally nothing in the original to correspond with them! These words are erroneously used in the Sikh context. The first distorts the Gurus' vision of the transcendent One into a male God. The second reduces their multiple concepts of the Divine to merely a single concept of a Lord. The third dichotomizes the fullness of their experience into body and

Soul. Instead of arcades that would allow the light to emerge, these English terms obstruct the natural luster of the Sikh text. They choke its intrinsic spirit.

When I was working on my volume of translation,¹⁰ I did not make any use of them and had no problems whatsoever. English is a rich language and can touch the original Punjabi in many tender ways. The problem I encountered was the five male readers who were reviewing my work, and they were particularly unhappy with my omission of these words. I could hear loud sighs from my five readers. ‘What a pity I was not using the beautiful term “Lord”,’ they lamented again and again. By clinging to established translations we put words into a mold that destroys their vitality and we end up freezing ideas and congealing emotions. We go totally against the original. I strongly suggest Sikh scriptural translations be free of these western terms and their value systems.

Translating without God

Let us read the mulmantra in the original. It is the opening of the Sikh scripture, and is regarded as the quintessence of Sikh metaphysics:

ikkoankarsatnamkartapurakhnirbhaunirvairakalmuratajunaibhangurprasad

This is how I translate it:

There is One Being
 Truth by Name
 Primal Creator
 Without Fear
 Without enmity
 Timeless in Form
 Unborn
 Self-existent
 The gift of the Guru

I will now cite another translation, which is ‘the fruit of the joint labours of the most eminent Sikh theologians and scholars of the day’ – Dr Trilochan Singh, Bhai Jodh Singh, Kapur Singh, Bawa Harkishen Singh and Khushwant Singh. This popular and authentic volume published by Unesco was revised ‘from the point of view of English style’ by George S. Fraser. It is introduced by Radhakrishnan and it has a foreword by Arnold Toynbee. When we read the version of the Sikh mulmantra produced by the intellectual elites from east and west, we receive an entirely different meaning and sensibility:

There is one God,
 Eternal Truth is His name;
 Maker of all things,
 Fearing nothing and at enmity with nothing,
 Timeless is His Image;

Not begotten, being of His own Being:

By the grace of the Guru, made known to men.¹¹

In this malestream translation, Guru Nanak's unique expression of *Ikk Oan kar* is 'weighted with a heavy, alien meaning' of God. There seems to be no effort to read Guru Nanak's unique expression with any intimacy; the translated version comes across as a mere imitation of biblical phrases. In Nanak's configuration of '*Ikk Oan Kar*' (1 Be-ing Is), three modes of knowledge have been used to signify the divine – numerical, alphabetical, and geometrical. '1' is the primary number, followed by the alpha of the Gurmukhi script, and the geometrical arch. While the former two constitute the beginning of the mathematical and verbal languages, the arch is at once without beginning or end. Nanak's fifteenth-century India abounds with eloquent terms and philosophically sophisticated concepts from Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, and from the Dravidic languages. Yet Nanak simply utters *Oan* after the all inclusive numeral '1'. *Oan* is the primal vocalic syllable of the Indian languages. The geometric arc flying off Nanak's *Oan* is a dynamic gesture of motion and movement. The circle is not closed, it cannot be closed. Nanak's perception of the ultimate is beyond gender and causality; it is spaceless and timeless. The *Guru Granth* begins with *Guru Nanak's* profoundly original articulation of the singular infinite.

Alas, the newness is lost in translation, and all the conventional theological phal-locratic figures blotted out in Nanak's fresh configuration are brought right back by the male western 'God' imposed by our translators. 'There is One God' is a mono-theistic conception, which does not quite invite the multiplicity and poly-imagin-ation of Nanak's numeral One. A specific male 'he', with pronounced male pronouns, horribly distorts Nanak's original language of plenitude and destroys the elemental modality of '*Ikk Oan Kar*'. The dynamic processes set in motion at the very outset of Sikh scripture are immediately aborted in the English translation.

As the *Jap* prelude continues, *Guru Nanak* links the creativity of the One with the virtue of fearlessness in the same breath. We can even spot the birthing process in the verbal root (*kr*, 'create'). The term *Maker* used in the translation is different from *creator*. The usage of '*Maker*' brings to mind the God from *Genesis* who makes the world out of nothing. A mother does not make; she creates, she bodies forth. The term *purakh* cast in iron masculinity in the *Unesco* translation is defined in the *Guru Granth* as both male and female: '*ape purakh ape hi nar – it itself is male; it itself is female*' (GG, 1020). Apparently, androcentric translations fail to see the Nanakian link between procreation and valor, and refuse to acknowledge the maternal substratum of the transcendent One. Throughout the 1,430 pages of Sikh scripture, the One is never translated, never recognized as a *She*. Instead Herculean muscle becomes the sole signifier. With '*nirbhau*' (without fear), a strong male dictator standing far above his creation with no body to answer to is fixed in imagination. Life does not develop from the fear of Him standing out there, but from the love that *She* has for all of her creation. The cosmos is bodied forth in love and not in animosity (*nirvair*) towards any offspring. In the memorable scene from the epilogue to the *Jap*, the whole universe plays in the 'lap of day and night, the male and female nurses – *divas rat dui dai daia kehle sagal jagat*'. Once they come out of their mother's body, all the variegated and complex creatures freely and delightfully cradle on the melodious

body of night and day. Without rivalries and enmity, they are together nestled on her body. Nanak's Jap, the first scriptural hymn, constitutes a remarkably organic textual body in itself, for the latent and hidden womb of its prologue proliferates into the open and spacious lap of its epilogue.

Like the colonial masters in India, the masculine God from the Jewish and Christian syntax rules over all aspects of Sikh scriptural translations. The western model is so internalized that Adam, who is given the role to name all the creatures and made in the image of God in the Genesis account, is reflected in the above Unesco translation of *akal murat* – 'Timeless is His image'. Similarly, assimilating Nanak's One to the Second Adam, our intellectual elites render Nanak's *ajuni* as 'not begotten'. English translations of Sikh scripture resonate with the diction from the English translations of the Hebrew Bible and the New Testament. So Adam receiving his power from God exudes his dominance, and the female is cast out of Sikh scriptural translations.

Translating without Lord

The admiration that Christian theologians feel for 'Lord' is replicated with equal verve by Sikh theologians and translators. In his *Systematic Theology*, Paul Tillich reflects at length upon the impact of religious symbols in the western Christian tradition, and how they enhance rather than diminish the reality and power of religious language. For Tillich the two symbols of the Godhead are 'Lord' and 'Father'.¹² Theologically and psychologically they fully represent his conception of God. 'Lord' betokens fascination, mystery, authority; 'Father', love and sentimentality. The Lord – Father symbol basically upholds a hierarchical, patriarchal frame of reference from which the female experience is excluded. The Christian God is a loving God, but the Freudian 'Father figure' is not afar.¹³ This symbol system from the West has been adapted in Sikh scriptural translations, and the word Lord constantly takes over the language of the Gurus.

Now wherever a term like *sahib* turns up, I suggest we translate it as 'sovereign'. I find it a more accurate equivalent. Whereas the word 'Lord' is masculine alone, the term 'sovereign' is gender inclusive. Furthermore, a lord can be anything from the master of a tiny estate to the ruler of a country to the male God of Judaism and Christianity, whereas the term sovereign emphasizes the supremacy of a completely independent ruler, male or female, which is more in line with the intention of the Gurus.

But what is truly outrageous is that even when there is no mention of such a person in the original, translators most enthusiastically usher in a supreme male Lord in their English versions! Such scholarly 'accidents' recur with alarming consistency. Not only are they erroneous, but they also obstruct any new channels of relating with the divine. When Nanak invites 'let us sing of the treasure of virtues – *nanak gaviae guni nidhan*' (GG, 2), translators circumscribe a masculine mold: 'O Nanak, sing of the Lord, the Treasure of Excellence' (srigranth.org). Such a 'lordly' intrusion undermines Nanak's transcendent vision. In fact this verse comes from the stanza that begins with Guru Nanak's insistence that the infinite 'cannot be shaped; cannot be made – *thapia na jae kita na hoe*.' Nanak's message is completely overturned by the male portrait drawn by our translator.

This incessant reliance on a male figure hampers Gurus' multiple jouissance. Their verses trigger infinite ways of relating with the divine. For example, when we read the scriptural verse 'ma n tan rata rang sio – mind and body so infused with color' (GG, 32), every bit of ourselves begins to infiltrate with radiance. Our imagination is seduced and a transcendent joy rushes through us, male and female alike. But with the thrust of 'Lord' and/or 'God' that flow gets clogged. We can check out our own response as we read the various translations: 'Their minds and bodies are dyed in the Color of the Lord's Love' (sriganth.org); 'Their mind is Immersed in the Love of the Lord' (Gopal Singh 1960, 34); 'Their mind and body saturated with joy in God' (Talib 1977, 71). Love of the Lord? Joy in God? In the original there is sheer rang: color. In the English translations, whether consciously or unconsciously, fathers and authority figures – much as we may love them and they us – take over our psyches, and instead of being suffused with primal joy, we are subdued. The Guru's inclusive rang (color) stretches our imagination and imbues our arteries with the brilliant color of our infinite cosmos, heightening us sensuously, emotionally and intellectually. (Notice: Dr Gopal Singh's translation of man -tan/ mind-body retains the mind but omits the body!) The transparency and power of the Guru's original is terribly lost in English versions. Translation is not an interpretation and our scholars need not feel the necessity to provide us with their erudite commentaries.

It is heartening to hear the Gurus unabashedly express their attachment to the divine through intimacy between mother and child: 'har seti man bedhi meri jindurhiai jio balak lag dudh khire – my mind is attached to the divine like the child for the mother's breast' (GG, 538). However, as usual, our translators give primacy to the tremendous figure of Lord who completely overshadows the mother – child union. According to Dr Gopal Singh, 'My mind is attached to the Lord as the child to the mother's milk.' According to G. S. Talib, 'My self! With the love of the Lord is my mind pierced even as the babe to milk attached.' A commanding masculine presence and hackneyed English phrases couched in a Victorian sensibility penetrate the simple universal maternal world of the original text. The language of the original is dynamic, but 'Lord' commits matricide. I really don't have the words to capture the deplorable way it kills the nurturing imagery of Sikh scripture. You'll have to see it for yourselves in the following conspicuous case:

Nanak's effervescent mnemonic reads, 'ape bachara gao kheer – that One is the calf, She is the cow, She is the milk' (GG, 1190).

In Dr Gopal Singh's translation, the same verse is absurdly transformed into: 'Himself is the Lord the Cow, the Heifer, the milk.' Such translations force us into a male world where cows are masculine lords and men lactate.

The Sikh Gurus wished to open us to our primal maternal imaginary, but the translators stick to their conventional male stereotypes. They deflect us from retreat-ing to those initial moments where we could relearn the primal relationships we experienced in our mothers' oceanic womb. If we could return to her lap, to her embrace, to her caress, our splintered and dichotomized self could become whole again. But the imposing Lord-God prevents us from returning to our first home and gaining our true subjectivity.

Translating without Soul

Like the words God and Lord, the word Soul vigorously appropriated by translators is totally inappropriate in the Sikh context. Laden with Jewish-Christian connotations, the soul imposes the mind – body dualism, shifting our focus from here and now to an afterlife and heaven out there. Feminist scholars have shown us the terrible consequences of this bipartite framework on the devaluing of our bodies, our life on earth, and of female gender and sexuality.¹⁴ In spite of the fact that Sikh scripture itself contains no soul, we find it lavishly present in English translations. Its usage dichotomizes the fullness of the Gurus' experience and vision, and sends misogynistic and misgeophobic messages to readers.

For the Sikh Gurus there no difference between here and there: 'Whatever lies in paradise beyond can be found in the body here – jo brahmande soi pinde' (GG, 695). The body is our marvellous possession, for its material is the divine and there is no split between any matter and spirit: 'Body is the home of the divine One and by the divine One is the body maintained – kaia harimandiru hari api savare' (GG, 1059). Therefore life is extremely precious (nirmol):

eh manak jio nirmol hai io kaudi badlai jaey

This pearl-like precious life goes for a pittance

(GG, 22)

Now this same verse in another translation centers on the body – soul dichotomy: 'jewel of the soul is priceless, and yet it is being squandered like this, in exchange for a mere shell' (sriganth.org). In the original there is no body – soul split: life without the experience of the divine is worthless; life with the divine experience is precious. The original – eh (this) manak (pearl) jio (life) nirmol (precious) hai (is) orients us to our origins, to our birth, to our mothers, to our family, to our community, to our life here and now. Sikh verses constantly inspire us to snugly integrate our bodies, senses, mind, consciousness, so that we enjoy our passionate relationship with the divine and inspire all aspects of life.

It is shocking to find palpable and healthy scriptural sources metamorphosed into ethereal souls in translation! The term jio means life, but as we see above, it is forcefully converted into a lifeless 'soul', which is then contrasted with the 'shell'. Now I am extremely grateful to website sriganth.org. To provide us with 1,430 pages of the scripture literally at our fingertips (in the original, trans-literation and translation) is a phenomenal achievement. Precisely because it is so accessible and valued, I feel the need to critique its consistent usage of Jewish and Christian vocabulary. Jio is not soul; it is life. Neither is jian 'souls'; rather it is beings/creation/people. Nor is jind soul; it is life. So when we read hukmi hovan ji (GG, 1), 'living beings [not souls] are born through divine precept'. When we read sabhna jia ka ikk data, 'all living beings [every body – not souls] share the One creator'.

And translators insert an extremely misleading interpolation whenever the text refers to women. Sikh scripture permeates with words like sakhi (female friend), suhagan (bride), nar, mahal and kaman (all three denoting woman). But whenever these original words are translated, the term 'soul' somehow gets latched on. A

simple suhagan, for example, becomes ‘bride -soul’. The nouns almost become adjectives. They lose their independence and are subordinated to the intrusive word ‘soul’. This bizarre process persists through the entire electronic translation, transforming strong flesh and blood female figures into ghostly metaphors. The following transliterations and translations come from sriganth.org, and I cite just a handful:

1. jinee sakheeN kant pachhaani-aa ha-o tin kai laaga-o
paa-ay. tin hee jaisee thee rahaa satsangat mayl milaa-ay.

(GG, 37)

I touch the feet of my sister soul-brides who have known their Husband Lord.
If only I could be like them! Joining the Sat Sangat, the True
Congregation, I am united in His Union

2. aavhu milhu sahayleeho mai pir dayh milaa-ay.

(GG, 38)

Come and meet with me, my sister soul-brides, and unite me with my Husband.

3. har var naar suhaavane mai bhaavai parabh so-ay.

(GG, 56)

With the Lord as her Husband, the soul-bride is happy; I, too, love that God.

4. mahlee mahal bulaa-ee-ai so pir raavay rang.

(GG, 57)

The soul-bride is called to the Mansion of the His Presence, and her
Husband Lord ravishes her with love.

5. Sobhavanti sohaagani jin gur ka het apar

(GG, 31)

The happy and pure soul-bride is noble; she has infinite love for the Guru.

6. jaa-ay puchhahu sohaagane tusee raavi-aa kinee gunee

(GG, 17)

Go, and ask the happy soul-brides, ‘By what virtuous qualities do you
enjoy your Husband Lord?’

I repeat: these translations and transliterations are from sriganth.org. The original presents vibrant scenes in which the females enjoy great respect and status. In the first instance the Guru bows to the female companions (sakhian) who have recognized the divine lover, and wishes to be fulfilled like them. The female friends represent the sat sangat, true congregation. The women are taken seriously, they are authentic

subjects, who are cognizant of the divine, and their company inspires union with the transcendent One. Again in the second example, the Guru solicits the company of female friends (*saheli*) so that he could meet with the divine. In the third he marvels at the beautiful bride (*nar suhavani*) who is with her divine groom. In the fourth he praises the woman (*mahal*) who enters the divine mansion and makes love with her divine partner. In the fifth he again admires the fortunate bride for her infinite love for the divine. In the sixth he wants to learn from the brides (*suha-gani*) their virtues, which enable them to savor the divine.

Clearly, in all these instances the female figures possess knowledge, they are morally and spiritually refined, they are beautiful, and they exist as palpable models for the human – divine nexus. As friends, companions, lovers and brides, they are embedded in a web of intimate relationships. In fact, the Guru wants to join their congregation. Women in the roles of sister, mother, sister-in-law are also quintessential to Sikh epistemology and spirituality. Guru Nanak identifies mother with wisdom: ‘*mata mati pita santokh* – mother is wisdom; father is content-ment’ (GG, 151), which is later repeated by his successors: ‘*mati mata*’ (GG, 172); ‘*mata mat santokhu pita*’ (GG, 1397). Socially engaged, the sister-in-law is regarded as ‘the most admirable member of her entire family – *sabh parvari mahi sreset*’, for ‘she guides her brothers-in-law, both younger and older – *mati devai devar jeset*’ (GG, 371). Throughout the Guru Granth women are vital subjects who are accorded a high status in the daily spheres of life. But by inserting the word ‘soul’, the fullness of their identity is severed. The ‘hyphen’-soul violates their intrinsic beauty and value. It annihilates their physical, psychological, mental, sensuous and spiritual self. It disconnects them from their immersion in society. It wrenches them from their rootedness in our planet earth. Their robust, authentic and respected presence becomes a mere figure of speech.

Our translators are so infatuated with God, Lord, Soul that one way or the other the female gets excised from their translations. Even the mother’s body, boldly expressed and affirmed in the verses of the Gurus, is repressed or deleted.

Whereas the Guru Granth explicitly affirms that the divine permeates both the heart and the womb (‘*ghati ghati vartai udari majhare* – It pervades every heart and flourishes in the womb’ [GG, 1026]), the translators and commentators of Sikh scripture simply deem it unnecessary to remember her body or our origins, and so the unique emphasis of the Sikh Gurus on the divine constitution of female physiology and of our integrated subjectivity is lost. In their English translations, both G. S. Talib and Gopal Singh register the heart (*ghat*) but utterly ignore the womb (*udar*) in Guru Nanak’s feminist sensibility.¹⁵ The particular female organ even gets altered into a generic ‘stomach’ or ‘belly’. The authoritative and most popular exegetical text, the *Sabdarath*, refers to *udar* as ‘pet’ (Punjabi word for ‘stomach’),¹⁶ and it is only natural that translators like our Internet resource would call it a ‘belly’.¹⁷ The radical vision of the Gurus and their invigorating over-tures thus remain unseen, unheard. Their womb-respecting, birth-oriented glimpses and melodies need to be remembered so that their lingering can make each of us more wholesome, and our world a better place. We must convey the liberating horizon of the Gurus both in our commentaries and in our translations.

There is also the tendency to delete references to ancient Hindu female figures from the original verses of the Sikh Gurus. Now there is no problem when there are scriptural references to a male god and his legendary activities. In fact, a Shiva or Indra or Rama is simply understood as a literary device with metaphoric associations. The male gods are understood as a matter of convention. As soon as the female is introduced, theologians and translators get all ruffled up, and fears and phobias begin to surface. The Goddess affects scholars and translators at a visceral level, which her male counterparts do not.

A prime example comes from the fourth spiritual realm expressed by Guru Nanak: 'karam khand ki bani jor – force is the language of karam khand' (Jap, 27). The junction where the individual seeking the divine meets with the benevolence of that One is indeed powerful, and so Guru Nanak's own language brims with might and strength. The Guru depicts this stage as full of valorous heroes and heroines. But the only one mentioned by name is the ancient Indian heroine Sita. Literally 'sita' means 'furrow', and prior to Valmiki's Ramayana, Vedic literature petitioned her as 'the mother of gods, mortals, and creatures'.¹⁸ Sita's primordial female energy and her creative abundance permeates the spiritual realm of karam khand. Guru Nanak presents the ancient Indian paradigm of female power in the plural – 'sita sita'. His usage of 'sitas' not only increases the figures numerically, it also takes away the distant 'goddess' stature of Lord Rama's wife, and makes women like Sita accessible and realistic members of society. Guru Nanak admits that language fails to describe their beauty: 'their form is beyond word – ta ka rup kathia na jae' (Jap, 37). Whereas the Sikh Guru clearly reproduces and magnifies the traditional Indian figure, the patriarchal exegetes of his text try to dismiss and disfigure her. G. S. Talib shrugs her aside: 'It would be superfluous to dilate on the symbolic character of Sita as representative of all that is noblest and purest in human nature.'¹⁹ Other exegetes reduce the life-blooded woman to the process of 'stitching'. In his popular text published by the Shromani Gurdwarara Prabandhak Committee, Professor Kartar Singh explains Nanak's usage of sita-sita as 'perfectly stitched' – 'puran taur te seeta hoia'.²⁰ Sita, and women like Sita, are misappropriated into a man 'stitched' in devotion. Still other interpreters of the Jap congeal the lively Sita and her companions into solid ice (deriving the term sita from sheeta, meaning 'cold')!²¹ And the Sikh intellectuals in our Unesco translation simply have no place at all for Sita! Their translation elides her completely from the text:

There dwell doughty warriors brave and strong,

In whom is the lord's Spirit,

And who by His praise are blended in Him . . .²²

The female victors of Indian mythology become victims of Sikh male hermeneutics with the result that the rich Sikh literary resources are deplorably reduced. I want to be very clear that I am not misunderstood. So I repeat what I have been saying over and over: the Gurus do not worship the goddess. They loudly prohibit Sikhs from worshipping any deity in chants, images or idols. The Gurus categorically denounce any form of idolatry. That would be a way of divorcing the external from the internal, the ideal from the real. In the Sikh world, Sita, Parvati, Durga, and women like them, are the continuum of the Body from whom we are created, the

Body, which is reproduced in our sisters, our daughters, our wives, our friends. Without being deified, the female figures are cherished as strong, compassionate, intelligent, and creative personalities by the Guru-poets. We cannot erase Sita (or Durga- Kali as in the case of Guru Gobind Singh) from the expansive vision of the Gurus because that would disrupt the infinity of the One. These heroines substantiate the Sikh Gurus capacity for and interest in seeing her as an active agent. The wide range of humanity envisioned by the Sikh Gurus has the potential to activate our conscious and unconscious selves. Their comprehensive imagery broadens our mental landscapes and affects our attitudes and actions towards one another. Inversely, by excising the female mythological figures from their compositions, by excising the female configurations, we fail to utilize their broadmindedness. We only perpetuate insularity, exclusivism and sexism. We need our heroes and our heroines and both should have equal place in translations.

Such deliberate or accidental deletions are active processes that Jackie Byars defines as processes of 'selecting and presenting, of structuring and shaping, of making things mean'.²³ The misrepresentations and excisions of the female person in Sikh translations are carried out by the male symbolic, which refuses to imagine the female sexuality of the Transcendent One. Generations of patriarchy have been programmed to fear her body, and this threat of her sexuality has kept readers from recognizing the female force and fecundity of Sikh sacred verse. Even when there is no gender specification, the pronoun 'he' rules with an iron fist. To insert a 'she' in place of the generic 'he' in translations would be sheer anathema. Sikh theologians fear idols, and yet by refraining from including the female imaginary in the vision of the formless One of their Gurus, they succumb to an idol of masculinity. They only end up making their 'monotheistic' religion into an 'androtheistic' one, which itself is a form of idolatry. Only in paternal codes has the divine been transmitted and received. Translation is not imitation; it is a deeply creative process. Terms like 'God', 'Lord' and 'Soul' have distinctive connotations and belong to a particular value system, so they should not be imported unthinkingly into translations of Sikh literature. Instead, we should intimately read the One infinite spelt out openly at the beginning of the Guru Granth, and search freely, confidently and independently for genuine equivalents between Punjabi and English.

Touch of the translator

I think the equality of Punjabi and English can be accomplished through Benjamin's ideal of the interlinear translation in which the translator goes for the literal rendering of the syntax rather than for the semantic content of sentences. When we focus on finding meaning of each word in the original, those semantic prejudices and hegemones have a tougher time penetrating. In the interlinear mode the two languages are literally parallel and so they come face to face as equals. This has been my own model too and I find it a most exciting experience. When I try to understand a word of the Gurus, I shift from my study in Maine to my home in the Punjab left far behind. A word in Punjabi opens up the familiar smells and sights and sounds that are so far away! From the serene white snows I am immediately transported to the bustling warm monsoons. It puts me in touch with the deepest recesses of my self and by

finding its English equivalent I recover the intrinsic harmony between two distant worlds.

There are challenges too. How does a translator communicate the aesthetic efficacy of the scriptural syntax? Without succumbing to any linguistic, grammatical or rational laws, the divine utterances come with a gusty speed and take on the most beautiful designs. The natural rhythms of the Gurus produce lovely alliterations and rhymes, assonance and consonance. It is amazing how their spontaneous verses flow out so perfectly into wonderful geometric patterns, arabesques of images, and somersaulting movements. The epilogue to Guru Granth mandates that we not simply eat but savor these delicacies put on the scriptural platter. Now how does a translator transmit the taste from one tongue to another?

Furthermore, how to maintain culturally specific idioms? Benjamin rightly reminds us 'that our translators have a far greater reverence for the usage of their own language than for the spirit of the foreign works'.²⁴ In our homogenized 'globalized' world, how does one translate the typical phrases of the Gurus? For example, Guru Nanak has a poetically charged verse, 'bholā vaidū nā jānāi karak kālē māhī – the naïve physician does not know that the pain lies in the liver' (GG, 1279). In the Punjabi idiom, *kālējā* ('liver') is the seat of love. How does one communicate *kālējā dā tukrā* (literally, 'piece of one's liver' to a culture that only knows of 'sweetheart')?²⁵ (Similarly there are several other terms which pose quite a challenge.) Actually, the English language is a pauper in the face of abundance of Punjabi words – *manmō-han*, *prītam*, *lāl*, *ravanhar*, *pyarā*, *kant*, *sahū* . . . In translating Punjabi we need to expand English with some intrinsically Sikh terms such as one, lover, divine spark, maternal womb . . . When there is a total reciprocity between English and Punjabi, there will be harmony, and we will recover the powerful affinity between languages.

Of course parallel lines only meet in infinity, so the meeting of the languages must never come to a close. Like the arch touching the Oan at the opening of Sikh scripture, translations must continue on, and they must be carried out by both men and women. So far we have only received them from the pens of male elites. And they have been in Victorian style. The translations must be renewed every generation. And the touch of the translator must not be heavy-handed – that would wall in the meaning – but rather, delicate and tender so that the original shines forth with its endless possibilities. The translator's touch can be like Benjamin's Aeolian harp, 'touched by the wind of languages'. Or, it can be like the intimate embrace of the scriptural woman snug in the arms of her infinite One, '*dhan sacī sangutī hari sang sūtī*'. The light touch of music and the passionate embrace of woman will put us back in touch with our fundamental humanity.

Notes

- 1 Benjamin 1969, 72.
- 2 Its 'International Edition' titled Sri Guru Granth Sahib: English Version was published by the World Sikh University Press (Chandigarh, India) in 1978.
- 3 See Sandra Bermann's introduction in Bermann and Wood 2005, 1 – 2.
- 4 Spivak 1993a, 183.
- 5 Spivak 2005, 94.
- 6 Spivak 1993b, 185.
- 7 Yeats and Swami 1937 [1975], preface, 7 – 8.
- 8 Bassnett and Trivedi 1999, 2.
- 9 Benjamin 1969, 79.
- 10 Kaur Singh 2002.
- 11 Singh et al. 1960.
- 12 Tillich 1951, 241.
- 13 Freud 1961, 33.
- 14 See, for example, Jantzen 1999.
- 15 Talib 1987, vol. 3, 2098: 'In each being's heart pervasive . . .' See also Gopal Singh 1960, vol. 4, 979: 'And he pervaded the hearts of all . . .'
- 16 Sabdarath Sri Guru Granth Sahib 1964, vol. 3, 1026.
- 17 See gurbani.org, which for the most part is very thorough and accessible. Never-theless, it uses belly for womb on page 1026.
- 18 Kinsley 1989, 93.
- 19 Talib 1977, 135.
- 20 Singh 1996, 72.
- 21 The term 'Sita' is taken by some exegetes in the sense of seetal (cold). For example, Harbans Singh 1963, 230. Even in his commentary, Japuji: The Immortal Prayer-Chant, G. S. Talib includes the possibility of its meaning 'cold'. He writes: 'Sito Sita in the line may be either Sita by herself – that is few other like Sita attain to that realm. Or sito may be an epithet, meaning cool (Shital) of great poise, one who has subdued all passion' (135). For a balanced discussion of this verse, see Singh 1970, 236 – 38.
- 22 Singh et al. 1960, 50.
- 23 Byars 1991, 69.
- 24 Benjamin 1969, 80.
- 25 See my introduction in Kaur Singh 2002.